VI.

What long appeared to be a static security environment in Asia has dramatically changed over the past two decades. In the decades after World War II, Asia's leading nations focused on rebuilding from the devastation of the war, privileging economics over military policy. Tokyo subordinated much of its security within the framework of the US alliance, while China reeled from the domestic catastrophe of Mao's rule. A largely pacifist Japan and internally focused China did not conduct major military operations outside their borders, with China's 1962 war with India and its 1979 war with Vietnam being exceptions.

Since the end of the Cold War, however, the two began significant modernization of their militaries, in part in reaction to other regional trends, such as North Korea's nuclear and missile programs or the perception of US disengagement from the region. Today, on security matters, there is a far more direct struggle for influence and power in Asia between Beijing and Tokyo. This may sound odd when applied to Japan, which is well known for its pacifist society and the various constitutional restrictions on its military, but the past decade has seen both China and Japan seek to break out of traditional security patterns. In particular, Beijing is focused on the United States, which it sees as a major threat to its freedom of action in the Asia-Pacific region. But observers should not dismiss the degree to which Chinese policy makers and analysts worry about Japan, in some cases considering it an even bigger threat than America; this has led to a reaction in Japan fueling force modernization in light of China's dramatic military buildup.

Neither Japan nor China has any real allies in Asia, a fact often overlooked when discussing their regional foreign policies. They dominate, or have the potential to dominate, their smaller neighbors, making it difficult to create bonds of trust. Moreover, memories of each as an imperial power are ever present in Asia, adding another layer of often unspoken wariness.